

Day-One Integrity Operations Manual

Policies, SOPs, Reporting Paths, Investigation Tools & Implementation Queue

Version 0.2 | September 18, 2026
[[ORGANIZATION_NAME]]

Founding draft for adoption and Tennessee nonprofit counsel review. These documents intentionally set internal standards stricter than many legal minimums.

Operating principle

Controls must work when the complaint is inconvenient, when the accused person is powerful, and when disclosure could embarrass the institution. If a process only works when leadership voluntarily cooperates, it is not a safeguard.

Contents

- Conflict & Related-Party Policy
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Conflict of Interest and Related-Party Transaction Policy

Purpose

Protect charitable assets and decision integrity by identifying interests before they influence action.

Covered persons

Directors, officers, senior spiritual leaders, finance staff with approval authority, committee members exercising board authority, and other persons designated by the board.

Disclosure

Covered persons complete an annual disclosure and update it within 14 days after a material change. Disclose financial interests, family relationships, business relationships, gifts, debts, outside offices, vendor relationships, property transactions, and any other circumstance reasonably creating divided loyalty or apparent conflict.

Decision procedure

1. Chair or secretary records the disclosure.
2. Disinterested decision makers determine whether a conflict exists.
3. The interested person may answer factual questions but then leaves deliberation and vote.
4. Decision makers consider alternatives and fairness to the organization.
5. Minutes record the disclosure, recusal, persons present, alternatives/comparability considered, vote, and rationale.
6. Material related-party transactions require independent legal/accounting review when prudent.

Prohibited shortcuts

Founder approval, spiritual endorsement, donor pressure, urgency, or board unanimity that includes the interested person does not cure a conflict.

Enforcement

Failure to disclose or honor recusal requirements may support corrective action, repayment, removal from authority, or discipline, subject to due process.

Executive and Insider Compensation Approval SOP

Use for the chief executive, founder when compensated, senior leaders treated as insiders/disqualified persons, and material severance or housing/benefit arrangements.

Required file before compensation starts

1. Role description and expected time commitment.
2. Total-compensation inventory: salary, bonuses, housing, retirement, insurance, allowances, reimbursements, deferred compensation, severance, loans/forgone interest, and other economic benefits.
3. At least three appropriate comparability points when practicable, considering role, geography, organization size, complexity, and qualifications.
4. Written conflict screen identifying all decision makers.
5. Draft compensation resolution.

Approval

Only disinterested directors vote. Approval must occur in advance. The minutes or compensation memo document the terms, date, decision makers, comparability data, conflicted-person actions/recusal, and basis for concluding compensation is reasonable.

Annual review

Review total compensation at least annually and whenever duties materially change. Automatic founder increases, percentage-of-donations arrangements, and self-approved benefits are prohibited.

Financial Controls and Stewardship SOP

Minimum controls

- Board-approved annual budget and quarterly budget-to-actual review.
- Separate roles for authorization, custody/payment, bookkeeping, and reconciliation to the extent staffing permits.
- Monthly bank reconciliations reviewed by someone who did not prepare them.
- Dual approval for payments above a board-set threshold and for all insider/related-party payments.
- No blank checks, shared banking credentials, undocumented cash funds, or personal accounts used as corporate accounts.
- Expense reimbursements require receipts/business purpose; insider exceptions require disinterested approval.
- Restricted gifts tracked by fund/restriction.
- Asset register for real property, vehicles, major equipment, and high-value portable items.
- Written reserves and investment policy once liquid assets become material.
- Quarterly financial packet: statement of activities, financial position, cash report, budget variance, restricted funds, major payables, debt, and related-party activity.
- Annual outside-accountant review level determined by board based on size/risk, with a goal of progressively stronger assurance as resources grow.

Donation integrity

Giving is voluntary. Fundraising shall not promise spiritual status, healing, salvation, prophetic access, protection from supernatural harm, office, or preferential treatment in exchange for money/property.

Safeguarding Children and Vulnerable Persons - Tennessee Operations Policy

Governing rule

No spiritual office, confession practice, clergy privilege claim, reconciliation process, or internal investigation may be used to delay or obstruct a report required by applicable law.

Tennessee reporting

Tennessee DCS states that everyone in Tennessee is a mandated reporter of suspected child abuse or neglect. When facts reasonably indicate suspected abuse or neglect, personnel shall make the required report promptly through the Tennessee Child Abuse Hotline / reporting system and call 911 for an emergency or life-threatening situation. Internal notice does not replace the external report.

Prevention controls

- role-appropriate screening and lawful background checks before unsupervised access;
- two-adult or open/observable-environment rule, with narrowly documented exceptions for genuine emergencies;
- no secret electronic communication with minors; guardians included or approved platforms used;
- written transportation, overnight, bathroom/changing-area, photography/media, and physical-contact rules;
- no adult/minor romantic or sexual conduct; no grooming behavior;
- annual safeguarding training for covered personnel;
- code of conduct acknowledgement and boundary training;
- visitor/check-in controls appropriate to program size.

Response

1. Ensure immediate safety; call 911 when necessary.
2. Make required external report; do not investigate first to decide whether reporting is deserved.
3. Preserve records and avoid suggestive questioning.
4. Notify the safeguarding lead unless that person is implicated; then notify the independent board channel.
5. Apply interim access restrictions when reasonably necessary.
6. Coordinate internal employment/volunteer response so it does not interfere with authorities.
7. Offer survivor-centered support and independent resources without conditioning support on silence, reconciliation, forgiveness, or continued participation.

Records

Safeguarding files are access-restricted and retained under counsel-approved schedules. Never promise absolute confidentiality where reporting or safety duties apply.

Complaints, Whistleblowing, and Non-Retaliation SOP

Intake channels

Maintain at least: (1) a normal internal contact; and (2) an independent channel controlled by the Safeguarding and Institutional Integrity Committee or external provider. Publish both.

Intake workflow

1. Date/time stamp; assign case ID.
2. Acknowledge receipt promptly when contact information is available.
3. Triage for immediate safety, mandatory reporting, criminal conduct, evidence preservation, retaliation risk, and conflicts.
4. Route complaints involving senior leadership directly to independent oversight.
5. Adopt interim protections that are nonpunitive where possible.
6. Determine resolution path: information response, management correction, mediation only if freely appropriate, formal investigation, safeguarding referral, HR process, or external authority.
7. Record outcome and appeal rights where applicable.

Non-retaliation

Prohibited retaliation includes firing/removal, schedule or housing manipulation, threats, shunning directives, public humiliation, doxxing, spiritual condemnation targeted at the reporter, witness pressure, donor pressure, exclusion from ordinary services, or adverse action materially motivated by protected reporting/participation.

Anonymous reports

Anonymous reports are accepted. Investigators should distinguish inability to corroborate from proof that an anonymous report was false.

Bad faith

Knowingly fabricated allegations may be misconduct, but inability to substantiate an allegation is not by itself evidence of bad faith.

Independent Investigation Protocol

Independence trigger

Use an external or otherwise demonstrably independent investigator for allegations involving the founder, chief executive, director, lead clergy executive, safeguarding lead, finance lead, retaliation by leadership, substantial financial impropriety, abuse, or any matter where ordinary management has an actual/apparent conflict.

Pre-investigation controls

- external-reporting obligations addressed first;
- litigation hold / evidence preservation when appropriate;
- investigator conflict screen completed;
- written terms of reference approved by disinterested authority;
- retaliation and witness-contact instructions issued;
- interim safety measures considered.

Investigation standard

The investigator should determine facts using a stated civil/administrative standard (normally preponderance / more likely than not unless counsel directs otherwise), separately identify corroborated facts, disputed facts, credibility considerations, policy conclusions, and matters outside scope.

Fair process

The respondent receives sufficient notice of material allegations and a meaningful opportunity to respond, subject to safety, privilege, and legal limitations. Complainants and witnesses are not promised outcomes or absolute confidentiality.

Report

The report states scope, methodology, evidence reviewed, interviews, factual findings, policy analysis if requested, limitations, unresolved issues, and recommendations only if within mandate. The board, not the investigator, normally decides corporate sanctions unless mandate provides otherwise.

Publication

Public summaries should prioritize accountability while protecting victims, minors, medical information, personnel privacy, legal privilege, and investigative integrity.

Discipline, Removal, and Appeals SOP

Minimum due process

For material discipline affecting office, employment, voting membership, credentials, or access to significant organizational privileges:

1. Written notice of the rule/standard and material facts alleged.
2. Disclosure of decision maker and conflict check.
3. Reasonable opportunity to provide evidence and response.
4. Impartial decision based on the stated record.
5. Written outcome with findings sufficient to understand the basis.
6. Proportionate corrective action.
7. Appeal to a person/body not materially involved in the original decision.

Prohibited discipline grounds

Good-faith criticism; protected complaint/report; lawful contact with former members or critics; refusal to donate; refusal of optional ritual/counseling; accessing outside information; obtaining independent legal/medical advice; or resignation.

Restoration

Forgiveness, reconciliation, membership restoration, and restoration to authority are separate questions. No person is entitled to regain a position of trust merely because apology, repentance, treatment, or forgiveness has occurred.

Exit, Disaffiliation, and Former-Participant SOP

1. Any clear communication of resignation is effective without approval.
2. Staff shall not require an exit interview, payment, confession, doctrinal recantation, nondisparagement agreement, or spiritual release.
3. Administrative staff may offer an optional property/records checklist.
4. Personal property, final wages, earned benefits, and deposits are handled under ordinary law/contract, not religious standing.
5. Leaders shall not direct friends or family to sever ordinary relationships because of departure or criticism.
6. Confidential pastoral/personnel information remains protected after exit.
7. Former participants may criticize the organization. The organization may correct factual statements through ordinary lawful means but shall not retaliate or expose confidential information to punish criticism.
8. Threats, stalking, repeated unwanted contact, or safety risks are handled through ordinary safeguarding/security/legal channels, not theological labeling.

Pastoral and Spiritual-Care Ethics Code

- Respect conscience and informed consent.
- State qualifications and scope honestly.
- Do not diagnose or treat medical/mental-health conditions unless licensed and acting within scope.
- Refer to qualified professionals when needs exceed competence.
- Do not discourage lawful medical, psychiatric, psychological, legal, or financial advice.
- Maintain confidentiality subject to safeguarding, mandatory reporting, threats of serious harm, lawful process, and other stated exceptions.
- Never use confession, trauma history, sexuality, finances, family secrets, or spiritual fears as leverage.
- No sexual/romantic relationship during an active pastoral/counseling relationship or other substantial spiritual power imbalance.
- Gifts of material value from counselees require disclosure and, above policy thresholds, supervisory approval or refusal.
- Do not cultivate exclusivity: participants may consult other clergy, traditions, clinicians, advisers, and critics.
- Do not present personal impressions, dreams, visions, or prophetic claims as binding commands over another adult's life decisions.
- Document boundary concerns and seek supervision early.

Revelation, Doctrine, and Epistemic Integrity Protocol

Classification vocabulary

Every major teaching or institutional claim should identify its principal status where useful:

- **Evidence / record** - directly observed, documented, or source-based material.
- **Historical inference** - conclusion drawn from evidence with stated uncertainty.
- **Philosophical interpretation** - conceptual interpretation, not direct observation.
- **Theological hypothesis** - religious explanation proposed for consideration.
- **Communal teaching/tradition** - teaching adopted by the community.
- **Personal conviction / claimed revelation** - sincerely held personal spiritual claim.

Rule for extraordinary claims

Intensity, charisma, office, predictive success, altered state, dream, vision, or claimed divine source does not by itself create corporate authority.

Doctrinal change record

A material change should include: proposition; source/evidence; competing interpretations; arguments for/against; confidence; practical implications; rights impact; dissent; decision body; vote/consensus record; effective date; review date.

Hard stops

No revelation claim may: override safeguarding or mandatory reporting; authorize sexual access; transfer personal property without ordinary informed consent; set the claimant's compensation; decide the claimant's discipline; override another adult's healthcare/legal decisions; suspend the charter/bylaws; or require social shunning.

External Institutional Integrity Review - Standing Terms of Reference

Frequency

First review within 18 months of public launch; thereafter at least every three years, with targeted interim reviews after major safeguarding, financial, retaliation, governance, or leadership crises.

Reviewer independence

Reviewer(s) shall not be current staff, founder relatives, material donors with governance leverage, routine vendors whose revenue depends materially on the organization, or persons with another relationship reasonably compromising independence.

Scope

- freedom of conscience and participant rights in practice;
- board independence and founder/leader power concentration;
- complaint accessibility and retaliation risk;
- safeguarding systems and case handling;
- investigation independence;
- financial conflicts/related-party transactions/compensation process;
- pastoral boundaries and information control;
- exit practices and former-participant treatment;
- housing/employment/education dependency risks;
- doctrine/revelation process and manufactured certainty risks;
- transparency and remediation culture.

Evidence access

Subject to privilege and lawful privacy limits, reviewer receives relevant policies, governance records, training data, anonymized complaint/safeguarding statistics, selected case files when authorized, financial-control evidence, leadership certifications, and remediation history.

Reporting

Classify findings by severity and systemic significance. Separate verified fact, control gap, cultural observation, and recommendation. The board publishes an appropriate summary and a remediation plan, then tracks actions to closure.

Annual Leadership Integrity Certification

Organization: [[ORGANIZATION_NAME]] **Year:** [[YEAR]] **Person:** [[NAME]] **Role:** [[ROLE]]

I certify, to the best of my knowledge after reasonable inquiry, that during the reporting year:

- I read and complied with the charter/bylaws provisions applicable to my role.
- I disclosed actual, potential, and apparent conflicts and updated them when circumstances changed.
- I did not participate in approval of my own compensation or a transaction in which I had a disqualifying interest.
- I did not retaliate against a complainant, witness, critic, dissenter, reporter, or departing participant.
- I did not direct institutional shunning for ordinary disagreement or departure.
- I did not use claimed revelation or spiritual authority to bypass consent, safeguarding, financial controls, or governance.
- I made or escalated required safeguarding reports known to me.
- I preserved records and cooperated with authorized investigations.
- I disclosed any suspected violation of these statements below.

Exceptions / disclosures: [[NONE OR DESCRIBE]]

Signature: _____ Date: _____ Reviewed by: _____

Operational Forms

Board / Committee Minutes Template

Body: [[BOARD OR COMMITTEE]] **Date/time:** [...] **Location/method:** [...]

Present: [...] **Absent:** [...] **Guests/advisers:** [...] **Quorum:** Yes / No

Conflicts and recusals

[[Disclosure, determination, departure/return times, abstention]]

Matters considered

[[Agenda item]]

- Materials reviewed:
- Key facts / alternatives:
- Adviser reliance:
- Motion / resolution:
- Vote (for/against/abstain):
- Rationale / findings:
- Follow-up owner and due date:

Executive session

[[Participants, purpose, start/end; do not record unnecessary privileged/personnel detail]]

Certifications

Secretary: _____ Date: _____

Chair / Committee Chair: _____ Date: _____

Complaint / Whistleblower Intake Form

Case ID: [[AUTO]] **Received:** [[DATE/TIME]] **Channel:** [[...]] **Anonymous:** Yes / No

Complainant/contact (optional): [[...]]

Person(s)/unit(s) involved: [[...]]

What happened? Include dates, locations, witnesses, documents, and what you personally observed versus what you heard from others.

[[NARRATIVE]]

Immediate safety concern? Yes / No / Unknown

Possible child/vulnerable-person issue? Yes / No / Unknown

Possible crime? Yes / No / Unknown

Possible retaliation risk? Yes / No / Unknown

Requested support / accommodation: [[...]]

Attachments/evidence identified: [[...]]

Staff use: mandatory-reporting review completed by [[...]] at [[...]]; conflict screen [[...]]; routed to [[...]]; interim protection [[...]].

Safeguarding Incident / Concern Record

This form does not replace emergency services or a legally required report. In an emergency call 911. In Tennessee, suspected child abuse/neglect reporting duties apply broadly; make the external report first when required.

Record ID: [...] **Date/time concern learned:** [...] **Recorder:** [...]

Person potentially at risk: [[name/age/contact only as necessary]]

Person alleged to have caused risk/harm: [...]

Exact words / observations (avoid interpretation): [...]

Immediate safety actions: [...]

External report made? Yes / No / Not yet / Not applicable

Agency / confirmation / time: [...]

911 / law enforcement involvement: [...]

Internal safeguarding notice: [...]

Evidence preserved / location: [...]

Interim access restrictions: [...]

Follow-up owner: [...] Next review date: [...]

Tennessee Child-Safety Reporting Quick Card

Emergency / life-threatening: Call 911.

Tennessee Child Abuse Hotline: 1-877-237-0004

Online reporting: <https://apps.tn.gov/carat/>

Tennessee DCS states that **everyone in Tennessee is a mandated reporter** of suspected child abuse or neglect. Do not wait for an internal investigation, supervisor permission, clergy approval, or certainty. Preserve only the facts needed and avoid conducting your own forensic interview.

After the required external report, notify the organization's safeguarding lead unless that person is implicated; if implicated, use the independent board complaint channel.

Source checked September 18, 2026: Tennessee Department of Children's Services, Report Child Abuse.

Investigator / Decision-Maker Conflict Screen

Case ID: [...] **Person screened:** [...] **Role:** [[investigator / board member / adviser / decision maker]]

Disclose whether you have:

- family/intimate relationship with a party or key witness;
- employment/supervisory relationship creating dependency;
- financial/business relationship with a party;
- pastoral/counseling relationship relevant to the matter;
- prior involvement in the allegations or disputed decisions;
- public statements suggesting prejudgment;
- material donor/vendor relationship;
- other circumstance creating actual or apparent bias.

Disclosure: [...]

Determination: No conflict / manageable with limits / disqualified

Decision by: [...] Date: [...] Conditions: [...]

Investigation Terms of Reference

Case ID: [...] **Authorizing body:** [...] **Investigator:** [...]

Questions to determine

1. [...]
2. [...]

Policies/standards potentially implicated

[...]

Scope exclusions

[...]

Standard of proof

[[normally preponderance/more likely than not, unless counsel directs otherwise]]

Authority

Access to records/personnel: [...] External experts: [...] Privilege arrangements: [...]

Reporting line

Investigator reports to: [[independent committee/board/counsel]]

Safeguards

Evidence preservation; non-retaliation; witness-contact instructions; mandatory reporting; confidentiality limits.

Deliverables

Factual report / policy findings / recommendations (select). Target completion and status-report cadence: [...]

Investigation Interview Record

Case ID: [...] **Interviewee:** [...] **Role:** [...] **Date/time:** [...] **Method:** [...]

Interviewer(s): [...] **Support person/counsel present:** [...]

Purpose and confidentiality limits explained? Yes / No

Non-retaliation reminder given? Yes / No

Recording authorized? Yes / No / N/A

Account

[[Questions and substance of answers. Distinguish direct knowledge, inference, and hearsay.]]

Documents/evidence identified

[...]

Follow-up

[...]

Interviewee corrections/comments if record is shared for confirmation: [...]

Investigation Findings Report Template

Case ID: [...] **Investigator:** [...] **Date:** [...]

Mandate and independence

[[authority, conflict screen, reporting line]]

Allegations / questions

[...]

Method

[[records, interviews, limitations, standard of proof]]

Factual findings

For each allegation: **substantiated** / **not substantiated** / **inconclusive** / **outside scope** with evidence and credibility analysis.

Policy analysis

[[if within mandate]]

Safeguarding / retaliation / systemic-control observations

[...]

Limitations and unresolved issues

[...]

Recommendations

[[only if requested by mandate]]

Attachments / evidence index

[...]

Notice of Proposed Discipline / Removal

Recipient: [...] **Date:** [...] **Decision body:** [...]

Proposed action: [...]

Rules/standards implicated: [...]

Material factual basis: [...]

Evidence available for review subject to lawful confidentiality limits: [...]

You may respond by [[DATE]] through [[METHOD]]. You may identify relevant evidence and conflicts of interest. Retaliation against complainants/witnesses is prohibited.

Decision date/process: [...] Appeal route if action is imposed: [...]

Appeal Form

Case/decision ID: [...] **Appellant:** [...] **Date:** [...]

Decision appealed: [...]

Ground(s) (check and explain):

- material procedural error;
- undisclosed conflict/bias;
- material evidence not reasonably available earlier;
- finding unsupported by the record;
- sanction materially disproportionate;
- governing-document error;
- retaliation affecting process;
- other: [...].

Requested remedy: [...]

Supporting documents: [...]

Conflict concerns regarding appeal decision makers: [...]

Retaliation Report

Related case ID (if any): [...] **Date:** [...]

Protected activity (complaint, witness interview, criticism, report to authority, refusal, departure, etc.): [...]

Adverse action / threat / pressure: [...]

Person(s) involved: [...]

Dates/witnesses/evidence: [...]

Immediate safety or employment/housing risk: [...]

Requested interim protection: [...]

Route directly to the independent integrity channel when ordinary management is implicated.

Annual Conflict and Independence Disclosure

Name: [...] **Role:** [...] **Year:** [...]

List interests involving the organization or its senior leaders:

- employment/consulting/business;
- ownership in vendors/landlords/lenders;
- family/intimate relationships;
- loans/debts/guarantees;
- gifts/housing/financial support;
- shared property or ventures;
- outside nonprofit/business offices;
- litigation or material disputes;
- pastoral/counseling dependency affecting oversight;
- any other actual/apparent conflict.

Disclosures: [...]

I agree to update this form promptly when circumstances change and to follow recusal instructions.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Related-Party Transaction Approval Memo

Transaction: [...] **Interested person:** [...] **Relationship:** [...]

Business/exempt-purpose need: [...]

Alternatives considered: [...]

Fair-market / comparability information: [...]

Conflict disclosure and recusal: [...]

Independent adviser review (if any): [...]

Terms approved: [...]

Why the transaction is fair and in the organization's best interests: [...]

Disinterested vote: For __ / Against __ / Abstain __ Date: [...]

Compensation Approval Memo

Position/person: [...] **Effective date:** [...]

Total compensation elements: [[salary, housing, retirement, insurance, bonus, allowance, severance, etc.]]

Comparability sources: 1. [...] 2. [...] 3. [...]

Adjustments for geography/size/duties/experience: [...]

Conflicts and recusals: [...]

Disinterested decision makers present: [...]

Resolution: [...]

Basis for conclusion that compensation is reasonable: [...]

Vote: [...] Approval date: [...] Next review: [...]

Day-One Implementation Queue

Before filing / organizational meeting

- ☐ Select statutory-member or nonmember charter variant.
- ☐ Complete Tennessee charter placeholders and obtain counsel review.
- ☐ Identify at least five formation directors, majority independent; recruit to seven within 180 days.
- ☐ Conduct conflict and independence screening before directors vote on insider matters.

Organizational meeting

- ☐ Adopt bylaws and selected variant schedule.
- ☐ Adopt Participant Bill of Rights and Institutional Integrity Framework.
- ☐ Adopt Founder Covenant; serving founder signs.
- ☐ Adopt Reserved Powers Schedule.
- ☐ Appoint officers and standing committees.
- ☐ Approve bank/signing/payment authority matrix.
- ☐ Adopt conflicts, compensation, finance, safeguarding, complaint, investigation, discipline, exit, pastoral ethics, doctrine/revelation, and external-review policies.
- ☐ Establish corporate record book and document hierarchy register.

Before accepting public participants / donations

- ☐ Publish rights, complaint channels, safeguarding contact, leadership/board identities, and basic governance explanation.
- ☐ Activate independent complaint channel.
- ☐ Establish bookkeeping, bank reconciliation, restricted-fund tracking, and approval thresholds.
- ☐ Complete initial leader/director conflict disclosures.
- ☐ Approve any founder/executive compensation using disinterested process and comparability data.

Before serving minors/vulnerable adults

- ☐ Safeguarding lead appointed and independent escalation route active.
- ☐ Required screening/background checks complete.
- ☐ Covered workers trained.
- ☐ Reporting quick card distributed.
- ☐ Two-adult/observable environment, transport, overnight, communications, and media rules active.

First 90 days

- ☐ Recruit board to full 7-11 structure and achieve $\geq 2/3$ independence.
- ☐ Run first speak-up test / anonymous channel test.
- ☐ Run tabletop exercise: complaint against founder/chief executive.
- ☐ Run tabletop exercise: child-safety disclosure.
- ☐ Run tabletop exercise: related-party transaction.
- ☐ Complete first quarterly integrity dashboard.

First year

- ☐ Independent financial review level set based on resources/risk.
- ☐ Board self-assessment and leadership integrity certifications complete.
- ☐ Publish annual transparency report.
- ☐ Commission first external integrity review no later than 18 months after public launch.